

BRP: THE NIGHT CRAWLER

Event 91 · Basic Role-Playing (BRP) · Neo-Ashford, 2087 · 6 players · 3 hours 30 min · Friday 7:00 PM

Corporate dystopia / cosmic horror. A retrieval job. By the time they find Reth, the scenario has already changed.

GM TRUTH — DO NOT SHARE

Veltris Solutions purchased the derelict Sutter-Vane Water Reclamation Plant 18 months ago as a shell transaction. Their survey team found Sub-Level 9 already occupied by a Spawn of the Lurker at the Threshold — a semi-corporeal Mythos predator predating Neo-Ashford by centuries, possibly millennia. It does not think. It does not want. It extends, consumes, and grows, using organic filament networks to alter its environment and condition nearby organisms toward behaviour that serves its spread. 47 people have vanished from the surrounding six blocks in 18 months. The local authorities have been paid to file these as gang violence statistics. Veltris began studying the entity, then feeding it, then integrating it into a research programme under Dr Yava Chen, who has spent 14 consecutive weeks on-site and is no longer entirely herself. Data analyst Damos Reth accidentally accessed unredacted files six days ago, copied what he could to a data-chip, and ran to the Undertow — the only place in Neo-Ashford where corporate surveillance has gaps. Sable Morn hired the team as deniable assets. She has a standing arrangement with Veltris black ops to silence the team after delivery. The NDA they are signing covers exactly this scenario.

■ INTRODUCTION — VELTRIS BRIEFING (~15 min)

Locations: Veltris Solutions HQ — 40th floor reception suite

The elevator opens into a reception suite that smells of processed air and expensive polymer. The carpet absorbs sound. Sable Morn — late 40s, expensive coat, subdermal jaw comms — does not stand up. She looks at the wall slightly to the player's left when she speaks, as if watching something they cannot see. Job: find Damos Reth in Sub-Districts 7–9, recover him and a data-chip. Chip is the priority. 8,000cr each. Half now. The NDA: Research or Law 30% notices the biological material clause. Sable, if asked: 'Standard boilerplate from a separate division. Don't worry about it.' She does not look worried. She does not look anything. Insight 40%: she is not lying. She is simply not offering. The gap where the information should be is quite large.

Clues / handouts: 91-H00-A (Veltris NDA + mission briefing) · 91-H00-B (Reth dossier with corporate headshot)

Pacing: Atmosphere: Vangelis-style ambient during briefing. Shift to low industrial drone as they descend. The briefing room is one notch too clean.

■ ACT ONE — THE JOB (~55 min)

Locations: The Slab (elevated market, Sub-District 7) · Terminus Bar · Reth's Squat (Room 4, above the bar)

The Slab: elevated market under corrugated awnings — neon stalls, the wet chemical smell of the Undertow. A child approaches the Tech character specifically, presses a note: 'Don't go to the plant. My dad went. He didn't come back the same.' The paper has a faint chemical smell the Tech will not identify until the tunnels. Surveillance blind spots in Sub-District 7: corporate is hiding the entity's footprint from above. Why these six blocks? Where are the cameras? [Essential Clue 1] Terminus Bar: Jed Osler (Ghost's old contact from a decade ago — they owe each other one) confirms Reth came through, took a room upstairs, hasn't been seen in three days. Connects the disappearances to a smell rising from the drainage — sweetish, chemical, wrong — and a pattern of residents who left 'to get some air' and didn't return. [Essential Clue 2] Reth's Squat: corkboard on the wall — a map of Sub-District 9, hand-drawn from Veltris infrastructure plans. A red route marked to Maintenance Wash Pod 7. This is the navigational key to Sub-Level 9. [Essential Clue 3] Pinned at the bottom of the corkboard: the photograph. Photography/Art 40%: it is not doctored. The developing conditions were normal. The shape in the photograph should not be there. Do not describe it to players — only its effect. SAN 0/1D4. Reth's handwritten notes (91-H01-A) are here too — observations, a timeline, increasing panic in the handwriting.

Clues / handouts: Surveillance blind spots [E1] · Jed Osler's information — the smell and pattern [E2] · Corkboard map with red route [E3] · The photograph [Optional, SAN 0/1D4]

Pacing: Fallback if Jed is missed: the smell hits them as they approach the bar. Stealth 30% to notice movement in the drainage grate below the street.

■ ACT TWO — THE UNDERTOW (~65 min)

Locations: Entry Shaft · The Junction (drainage hub) · The Watching Room · The Feed Corridor · Maintenance Pod 7 (Reth)

Entry Shaft: corporate bypass on the lock — not Reth's work. Someone opened this from inside, recently. [Optional Clue] The Junction: drainage hub with six tunnel mouths, filament growth on walls and ceiling — organic, faintly bioluminescent, warm. The entity is physically present. Not attacking. Extending. SAN 1D4/1D10. Drone feed gap: something moved in frame that is not there when they look. [Essential Clue 4] The Watching Room: Veltris equipment, Reth's comms trail, partial internal files (91-H02-A). Feeding programme confirmed. Reth was marked for removal the moment the breach was logged. The team's payment was already the last transaction Sable intended. [Essential Clue 5] The Feed Corridor: three bodies. Former Security Team C, Month 11 of the programme. Splayed ribcages viewed from a distance. Clinical. Like flowers. No gore — what is wrong is the geometry. SAN 1D6/1D10. This is what the entity does to human beings — and why Reth sealed himself in a pod. [Essential Clue 6] Maintenance Pod 7: Reth (Persuade/Fast Talk 50% to convince him to open the door; Ghost's sub-district accent or his own words quoted back helps). Medicine 50%: filament tracery on his hands — integration timeline readable. Reth: 'It already knows your names. It knew them before you arrived.'

Clues / handouts: Entity present [E4] · Reth marked for removal; team payment was termination [E5] · Security Team C bodies [E6]

Pacing: The entity should feel like something that has always been there. Slow accumulation. The smell first. Then the warmth. Then the geometry of the bodies.

■ ACT THREE — ASCENT (~50 min)

Locations: Sub-Level 9 Containment Floor · Observation Gallery (Dr Chen) · Industrial Elevator / Stairwell (6 flights)

Containment Floor: 4 EM pulse barriers; 2 dead, grown through over months. Primary node visible through reinforced glass — transit-bus sized, radially symmetrical, slow constant motion. No eyes. The sense of being perceived is overwhelming regardless. SAN 1D4/1D10 (containment floor). SAN 1D10/1D20 direct sight of the node. Observation Gallery: Dr Chen at a terminal, finishes a line of notes before looking up. Academic, early 60s. Perfectly formed sentences with too much space between words. She answers every question honestly: the entity has been here since before the city; the barriers were always a delay; she has been here fourteen weeks and feels quite well. Perception/Insight 50%: her typing rhythm is not any human keyboard cadence. Extended conversation: POW vs Chen's POW 16 or 1 SAN loss from subtle cognitive alignment — make this roll secretly. Do not skip the Observation Gallery unless desperately short on time. Dr Chen is the most disturbing NPC because she is not monstrous. She is someone who has been remade slowly, and she is not unhappy about it. That is the worst of it. Ascent: 4 Veltris security, standing orders to prevent anything leaving Sub-Level 9. Stealth 50% to move undetected. MORAL CHOICE (must be at 3:05): (1) Walk Away — 8,000cr; entity continues; secondary node in Sub-D 4 unobserved. Team knows. (2) Expose Veltris — stock drops 12%, recovers in 6 weeks; plant liquidated to subsidiary who calls entity 'commercially promising.' (3) Destroy the Plant — Tech rigs power cell overload (10 min). During those 10 min, remaining barriers fail. Entity has 10 min in Sub-Level 9. Cannot reach upper floors in that time. Explosion destroys primary node. Civilian casualties: 15–30. Four are children. Combining all three: the timing mathematics do not work. Something has to give. Force this realisation.

■ EPILOGUE (~15 min)

Locations: Post-mission

Walked Away: transfer lands before they leave the building. Three weeks later one operative receives an anonymous photograph — every window in the surrounding six blocks dark; street empty; no people visible anywhere in the frame. Exposed: Reth makes the news for 18 hours before disappearing into rival corporate custody. Veltris stock recovers in six weeks. A subsidiary purchases Sutter-Vane assets in liquidation. Within 60 days: 'unusual biological material in sub-level infrastructure. Commercially promising.' Destroyed: explosion attributed to degraded industrial gas main. Official casualties: 9. Actual count (cold exposure, three weeks later): 23. Four are children. The Tech is paid — Sable can't prove anything. The operative who rigged the overload dreams about tunnels for the rest of their life. Not nightmares exactly. Tunnels, the faint organic sweetness, and something patient below the city. Primary node is gone. The secondary node in Sub-District 4 has no one watching it.

KEY NPCS

Sable Morn *Veltris Handler — the briefing room, the debrief, and nothing in between*

Expensive coat, subdermal jaw comms, grey-silver hair. Eyes rest slightly past whoever she's addressing — never landing. Professional completion. Not ideologically committed to the programme. Committed to Veltris's operation and her position. Has authorised worse. She does not unlock. There is no hidden warmth.

Damos Reth *Veltris data analyst, mid-level — hiding in Maintenance Pod 7*

Mid-30s, ordinary face, terrified. Filament tracery on both hands — integration timeline visible to Medicine 50%. Ghost's sub-district accent, the photograph, or his own words quoted back will reach him. If he survives: filament fades in 6 weeks with treatment. He knows what to do with information.

Jed Osler *Terminus Bar owner — Ghost's old contact*

Guarded. Treat with respect. Cash helps. Knows the smell, the disappearances, the pattern.

Won't go into detail about the drainage — but what he says is enough.

Dr Yava Chen *Veltris Research Director — on-site 14 consecutive weeks*

Academic, early 60s. Grey hair, reading glasses. POW 16 · Science(various) and Research skills at 80%+

Answers every question honestly. Not monstrous. Not happy or sad. The wrongness is in what she is honest about. Typing rhythm does not match any human keyboard cadence. POW vs 16 or 1 SAN from subtle cognitive alignment (secret roll).

The Entity *Spawn of the Lurker at the Threshold*

Semi-corporeal, ancient, non-conscious. Extends, consumes, grows. Uses filament networks to condition nearby organisms.

Cannot be conventionally defeated. Does not want. Does not think. Has been here since before the city. Killing humans is not the solution — the scenario should make this clear without punishing players for fighting.

PLAYER CHARACTERS

The Fixer *Persuade 65%, Fast Talk 60%, Insight 55%*

HP 12 · Licensed sidearm

Worked 3 Veltris contracts. Knows Sable always smiles at the debrief. Nobody who talks gets a 4th contract.

The Ghost *Stealth 70%, Spot 60%, Electronics 50%, Lockpick 55%*

HP 12 · Monoblade, jammer suite

Grew up in Sub-District 7. The Terminus Bar is known to them. So is Jed Osler. Coming back tonight feels like something they cannot name.

The Muscle *Firearms(Pistol) 65%, Brawl 60%, Intimidate 50%*

HP 16 · Military sidearm (2D6+2), baton

Ex-Meridian Security, Sub-Districts 1–4. Quit 18 months ago when disappearances started. Has been quietly making the connection.

The Tech *Electronics 70%, Drone 60%, Computer Use 60%*

HP 12 · Portable drone, EMP (1 use)

The child on the Slab approaches this character specifically. The note. The smell on the paper.

The Medic *Medicine 65%, First Aid 70%, Science(Biology) 50%*

HP 13 · Full trauma kit, bio-scanner

Colleague reported inward-growing tissue in thoracic cavities. 'We did not determine the entry point.'

The Analyst *Research 70%, Library Use 65%, Insight 60%*

HP 11 · Encrypted terminal

Anonymous encrypted message 2 days ago: coordinates in Sub-D 9 and three words: 'Don't go back.' Never been to Sub-D 9.

HANDOUTS

91-H00-A — Veltris NDA + mission briefing — corporate aesthetic; biological material clause buried in standard language

91-H00-B — Reth dossier — corporate file format; headshot; last known transit-chip ping Sub-D 7 Transit Terminus, 23:18, four days prior

91-H01-A — Reth's handwritten notes (crumple lightly before handing) — field observations, integration timeline, increasing panic in handwriting

91-H01-B — The Photograph (description card — NOT an actual image; hand separately at the right moment) — not doctored; conditions were normal; shape should not be there

91-H02-A — Veltris internal files (low contrast, dim terminal aesthetic) — feeding programme timeline; Month 11 casualties; Month 16 'Reth accessed restricted files. Recommend containment.'

SAN TABLE:

- The photograph (Reth's squat) **0/1D4**
- Filament growth at the Junction **1D4/1D10**
- Drone feed gap — something moved **0/1D4**
- Security Team C bodies (Feed Corridor) **1D6/1D10**

- Primary node — containment floor glass **1D4/1D10**
- Primary node — direct sight **1D10/1D20**
- Extended conversation with Dr Chen **0/1D4**
- Cognitive alignment (Chen, secret POW roll) **1 SAN flat**